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Variation in journal website characterization by an AI-driven "predatory" journal detector

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ABSTRACT

An AI-driven tool that claims to be capable of discerning suspected "predatory" from "normal" journals, the Academic Journal Predatory Checking (AJPC) System, was launched in early 2023. To date, several cases of likely classification errors of top-ranked journals by the AJPC System have been documented. In this paper, a new issue is raised about the AJPC System, namely conflicting classifications about a journal, depending on the journal's website that is used for a query, using the journal's top page, editorial board, or instructions for authors, as queries. Even though the AJPC System's top page warns users that only the journal's top page must be used for queries, authors might turn to a journal's other pages for testing. Ten journals from among the world's largest publishers were tested, and 50% of their classifications by the AJPC System were inconsistent, depending on the journal URL that was used. Inconsistent classification by the AJPC System across a journal's URLs is considered problematic for three reasons: 1) the absence of consistency can be equated with the absence of reliability; 2) academics who need to know a journal's scholarly standing may feel misled by contrasting output; 3) the reputation of scholarly journals may be at risk if they have been inaccurately classified by the AJPC System. An AI tool that is able to accurately identify a predatory journal using any journal's webpage is desirable for academics, but this first requires a clear understanding of what a "predatory" journal is. The AJPC System does not appear to be able to achieve either of these objectives reliably or consistently.

1. AI in science and technology, research and publishing

Artificial intelligence (AI) is now one of the frontrunner topics in academic publishing. This is because it forms an increasingly important part of invention and innovation (Bianchini et al., 2022), and through expanded knowledge discovery (Wang et al., 2023), it offers ideas that allow the research pipeline to be expanded and fortified (Messeri & Crockett, 2024). Emphasis is currently placed on the abilities of large language models (LLMs) to advance research ideas, and thus scientific innovation (Boiko et al., 2023; Mitchell & Krakauer, 2023), with the battle of ideas taking place at the level of ownership of ideas and authorship (Abernethy, 2025), and the ethics of how AI and LLMs (or generative AI) can or should be used in academic publishing (Kendall & Teixeira da Silva, 2024). As a subset of that ongoing struggle, there is interest by academics in knowing how AI and LLMs can be of practical use, either to advance knowledge and understanding, or to resolve practical problems. For example, when probed, the popular LLM ChatGPT provided almost no novel understanding of the phenomenon of "predatory" publishing, most likely because its "knowledge" was trained on ideas that humans – some perhaps misleading – had already published on this topic, although it was able to formulate its arguments eloquently and coherently (Tsigaris et al., 2023).

2. Human endeavor to classify the "predatory" nature of journals and publishers

The field of "predatory publishing" (McLeod et al., 2018; Grudniewicz et al., 2019; Inouye & Mills, 2021; Teixeira da Silva et al., 2022) aims to discern scholarly from unscholarly journals and publishers. To date, the classification of journals as either being scholarly, or not, has been the sole responsibility of humans. As with any human-centered endeavor, such classifications may be prone to subjectivity, biases, and imperfections. In addition to these human biases and imperfections – or perhaps as a result of them – criteria and classification systems that have to date served as the reference basis for academics, such as Jeffrey Beall's blacklists (or watchlists) or Cabells' Predatory Journal Reports, are – to some extent – unreliable and incomplete, and may contain false positives (Dony et al., 2020; Teixeira da Silva & Kendall, 2023a; Teixeira

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Fig. 1. Screenshots (top: English; bottom: Japanese) of inaccessibility of the website of the AJPC System, i.e., AI tool for detecting and discerning "suspected predatory journals" from "normal journals". Inaccessibility issues were first discovered in 2023, but these persisted in about November 2024 to March 2025.

da Silva et al., 2023). Those weaknesses result, in part, from the assumption that a classification is only binary, ignoring a range of publishing- and management-related characteristics that may lie in a gray zone in between (Yamada & Teixeira da Silva, 2022). Erroneous classifications might also arise from false assumptions about prevalence rate, leading to type I and II errors (Teixeira da Silva & Tsigaris, 2018, 2020; Tsigaris & Teixeira da Silva, 2020, 2021). An undesired outcome and risk of using erroneous, outdated, or inconsistent blacklists, or their classifications is that the output might be used to classify humans who might be affected by them, specifically authors who publish in journals that might be erroneously classified as "predatory", even more so when potentially erroneous classification systems are incorporated into publishing ethics clauses and guidelines (Teixeira da Silva, 2023a), or a negative stigma might be assigned to authors who may have published in truly "predatory" journals, even if their own work has merit (Teixeira da Silva & Kimotho, 2022). Human fallibility in judgement of what constitutes "predatory" or non-predatory can thus result in the potentially erroneous characterization of academics, or of journals and publishers, causing reputational harm (Teixeira da Silva, 2019). ChatGPT was used to try and differentiate scholarly (i.e., indexed in the Web of Science and the Directory of Open Access Journals) from "predatory" journals (i.e., on Beall's blacklists) (Al-Moghrabi et al., 2024).

3. Can AI assist in discerning a "predatory" from a scholarly journal?

In their seminal February 2023 publication in Springer Nature's *Scientific Reports*, and with surely good intentions in mind, Chen et al. (2023) employed AI, in the form of an open source Academic Journal Predatory Checking (AJPC)[2] System, as a support tool for academics to be able to distinguish "predatory" (or in their prose, "suspected predatory journal"; SPJ) from scholarly (or in their prose, "normal"; NJ) journals. Another AI-driven tool claims to have used machine-learning to make this distinction (Ateeq & Al-Khalifa, 2023), but that tool has not, to the author's knowledge, yet been practically applied. Over the past few years, several academics have argued for the need to have an automated system that is capable of making this distinction (Cukier et al., 2020; Koerber et al., 2020; Kratochvíl et al., 2020; Dadkhah et al., 2021; Yamada & Teixeira da Silva, 2025). In the ensuing two years following the launch of the AJPC System, concerted efforts were made to appreciate its strengths and weaknesses by testing the tool on actual cases. However, concerns began to emerge that some of the basic quality- and reliability-related tenants of the AJPC System, which claims to serve as a reliable tool to discern these two classes of journals, i.e., SPJs versus NJs, are not robust. Evidence for this critical claim lies in the following tests: using a web-scraping approach, the likely erroneous classification of a large body (about 17,500 journals) of mostly highly ranked and peer-reviewed journals – according to the Scimago Journal Rank (SJR) – across a wide range of scholarly publishers NJs as SPJs (Teixeira da Silva & Kendall, 2023b), including in the library and information sciences (Teixeira da Silva, 2023b), sport science (Teixeira da Silva & Scelles, 2024), psychology (Nebl et al., 2024), and FT50 (marketing, management, economics, etc.) journals (Teixeira da Silva et al., 2025), or the ease with which classifications can change or flip (Teixeira da Silva & Daly, 2023), all without any openness, transparency, accountability or explanation by the creators of the AJPC System, i.e., Chen et al. (2023). Compounding these issues in likely classification errors (or misclassification) is a website that is occasionally dysfunctional, leading to access errors (Fig. 1), thus limiting real-time analyses and replication trials.

4. Inconsistent classification by the AJPC System using intra-journal URLs

In this paper, a new potential flaw by this AI-driven "predatory" journal detector (i.e., the AJPC System) is revealed, namely that when different URLs of a journal's website are inputted, the output, i.e., the journal's classification, differs in most cases. Admittedly, and in its defense, the second usage instruction of the AJPC System indicates that the journal's top page must be used for testing (Fig. 2). Tests were run (21 September 2023) for 10 randomly selected journals (but broadly related

[2] https://140.113.207.51:8000/.

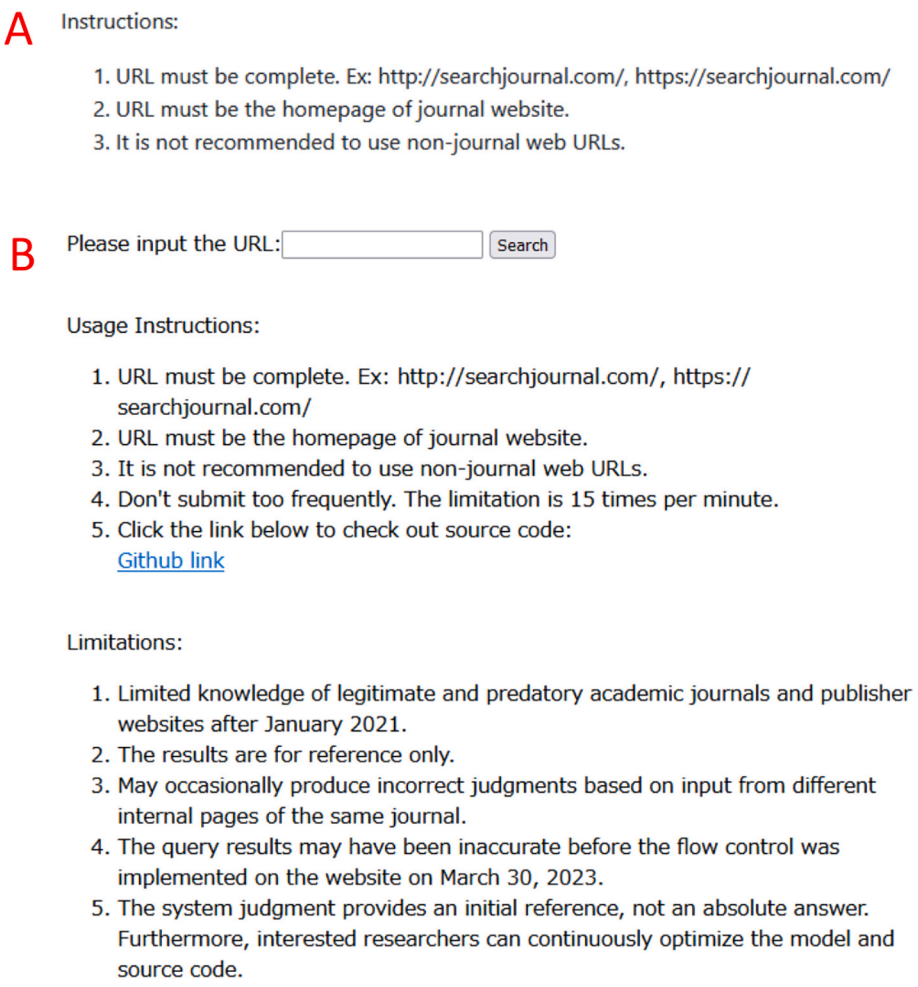


Fig. 2. Screenshots of the AJPC System top page, which indicates, in user instruction clause #2, that only the journal's top page should be used for investigating the classification of a journal as a normal journal or as a suspect predatory journal. However, several other clauses and limitations were not present on 15 March 2023 (A), while a memento at the Internet Archive reveals their presence on 29 August 2023 (B), suggesting their introduction at some point in between, although the precise date when these clauses and limitations were implemented or edited are not indicated. Date of screenshots: 21 October 2024. Screenshot sources: https://web.archive.org/web/20230315135409/http://140.113.207.51:8000/ (A), https://web.archive.org/web/20230829043544/http://140.113.207.51:8000/ (B).

to publishing, ethics or information sciences), one each for 10 of the largest publishers (in terms of journal volume) (Nishikawa-Pacher, 2022). The rationale for the selection of journal webpages, which were limited to three webpages or URLs for each journal, was as follows: 1) the top page, which authors are likely to access and to then input into the AJPC System; 2) the editorial board page, which authors might access to assess the legitimacy of a journal's editorial structure or composition; 3) the instructions for authors (IFA), to ensure that there are ethical clauses and other aspects that ensure the journal's publishing integrity. Regarding the reason for querying the editorial board page, as an example, prospective authors might detect an editor with a heavy retraction record (Teixeira da Silva, 2022; Teixeira da Silva & Vuong, 2023), and thus wish to query the scholarly legitimacy of the journal. Similarly, regarding the IFA, authors might detect odd or ethically-incompatible instructions or guidelines, and thus wish to query the scholarly legitimacy of the journal. As can be appreciated in Table 1 (with screenshot-based evidence in the Supplementary file), depending on the choice of each journal's URL, the classification by the AJPC System as either a SPJ or NJ changed. Of note, all journals examined had three distinct and unique URLs, except for InderScience, which had the same URL but with a drop-down menu for each functionality (for that reason, only one screenshot is shown in the Supplementary file). Of all 10 journals, 50 % were inconsistently classified as either a NJ or SPJ by the AJPC System, depending on the journal's URL that was used.

5. Conclusion and limitations

Without a doubt, humans would welcome the assistance by AI to overcome their failures and weaknesses, especially in terms of the biases and subjectivity that exist when they attempt to classify journals (or publishers) as either "predatory" or scholarly, so an AI tool that is able to make an impartial and objective classification is welcomed. However, the AJPC System appears to be under-performing, and in doing so, is it failing academia and prospective authors by presenting false positives or false negatives that translate into false journal classifications? There is a definitive limitation to the AJPC System's requirement for users to only use a journal's top page, because it might be very easy, convenient or desirable for a would-be author to select a journal's IFA or editorial page (or any of the journal's pages, for that matter) to test whether the journals is "suspected predatory". Consequently, the creators of the AJPC System have potentially set up a system that is only able to identify a fraction of related or relevant websites associated with a NJ or a SPJ. In defense, the AJPC System's authors, creators and managers could argue that they have clearly defined the input's limitations to users. Compounding this issue is the relative opacity related to changes in classification or the AJPC System code, and the inability to hold the authors (Chen et al., 2023), journal (*Scientific Reports*) and publisher (Springer Nature) accountable for the odd classifications discovered thus far. Ultimately, the authors are advertising an AI tool that is only partly

Table 1
Changes (or not) in classification in one representative journal each of the top 10 publishers, according to Nishikawa-Pacher (2022), depending on the input URL (top page, editorial, instructions for authors (IFA), as assessed by an AI-driven "predatory" journal detector (i.e., AJPC; Chen et al., 2023).

Journal[b]	Consistency of classification	Classification[a] using:		
		Top page	Editorial page	IFA page
Learned Publishing	Inconsistent	NJ	SPJ	SPJ
The Journal of Academic Librarianship	Inconsistent	SPJ	NJ	SPJ
Journal of Academic Ethics	Inconsistent	NJ	SPJ	SPJ
Research Ethics	Inconsistent	NJ	SPJ	SPJ
Accountability in Research	Inconsistent	NJ	SPJ	SPJ
Law & Ethics of Human Rights	Consistent	SPJ	SPJ	SPJ
Occupational Medicine & Health Affairs	Consistent[c]	SPJ	SPJ	SPJ
Research Evaluation	Consistent	NJ	NJ	NJ
International Journal of Information and Decision Sciences	Consistent[d]	SPJ	SPJ	SPJ
Research Data Journal for the Humanities and Social Sciences	Consistent	NJ	NJ	NJ

[a] Either as a normal journal (NJ), or a suspected predatory journal (SPJ).
[b] See the Supplementary file for corresponding publishers, as well as screenshot-based evidence of the classification of these journals by the AJPC System.
[c] Among these 10 publishers, OMICS is the only one found guilty of being a predatory publisher, as ascertained by a court of law (Manley, 2019).
[d] In this case only, as for all InderScience journals, there is only one URL, and the other pages can be access via drop-down functions on the top page, so the classification was the same in all three cases.

functional or that is partly dysfunctional.

There are two limitations to this paper and its findings: 1) there is merit in testing more journals across a wider range of publishers, and even though the tests can be automated (Teixeira da Silva & Kendall, 2023b), to obtain screenshot evidence, the task becomes arduous because it is manual; 2) more URLs within a single journal should be tested to appreciate a finer level of intra-journal variation in classification by the AJPC System. Even if the creators and managers of the AJPC System (i.e., Chen et al.) state that only the journal's top page should be used for queries, this disclaimer limits the tool's use by prospective authors and the public to test various URLs of a journal, where different evidence of scholarly or predatory behavior might exist. Even though the source code is provided at Github, it is not a user's responsibility to appreciate or correct the code's errors or flaws, and that responsibility lies exclusively with Chen et al. Moreover, even though the Github code does not appear to have been updated in months, it is understood that it can be modified by any person or entity, i.e., it is open to the public, opening it up to potential abuse and content manipulation. In addition, old versions of the Github code are not available, nor can edits made by the programmer or details of edits' users' be appreciated over time, suggesting that adjustments to the code are sub-optimal and opaque.

When an AI-driven system, like the AJPC System, is designed, it is normal to list limitations during the primary design, and the system is then evaluated based on those limitations. The design would then be fine-tuned to achieve better accuracy first, then to remove limitations, one by one. However, in two years of experience in testing the AJPC System, those limitations have been consistently present, suggesting that a problem might lie with the source code being used to train this AI tool. Even if truly predatory publishers might theoretically be able to surpass detection methods by the AJPC System in the future by, as one example, adjusting their journal's URL so that the top-page is unrecognizable, and thus avoiding being classified as a SPJ, the current stage of analyzing the NJ/SPJ status of journals has not yet reached that level of strategy.

Regarding the AJPC System, Tang (2025) concludes "we agree that the said machine learning-based tool lacks accuracy in its demarcation and identification of journals outside those already found within existing black and white lists, and that its use could have undesirable impact on the community" (p. 182), reinforcing the concerns drawn from the evidence in this study and prior analyses. There is thus a pressing need for greater transparency and robustness in the design and implementation of AI tools in academic publishing.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.eswa.2025.127933.

Data availability

Supplement

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